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Alan Broadbent

New Zealand native Alan Broadbent has distinguished himself as a jazz pianist, arranger, and composer. He has collaborated with a diverse list of artists, from Charlie Haden to Paul McCartney, and he is frequently called upon for his distinctive string arrangements.

Alan was interviewed via Zoom on October 26, 2023 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive. It's a great pleasure to have Alan Broadbent with me today. And I'm going to introduce you first as a pianist, orchestrator, arranger, composer, teacher, and just returned from San Francisco, is that right?

AB: Last night, yes.

MR: Yeah. You and I, I think, share something — there's something in common and probably with a lot of other people, and I read something that we both had a Dave Brubeck experience.

AB: Yeah.

MR: In our youth.

AB: Yes, yeah.

MR: Was that in New Zealand?

AB: That was in Auckland, in New Zealand, and I guess it was the time when a worldwide hit was "Take Five." And I was in between classical piano studies, which I wasn't too interested in, and trying to figure out what to do with music. And there was "Take Five" and that was very interesting. And they were doing a world tour at the time, I think this would have been '61, something like that. And anyway they came out and I had great seats and it was my first jazz experience hearing the Quartet, but mostly you know there was another level that was reaching me that I had never experienced. I knew the song that they would play, the standards, "Tangerine" and things from my dad's sheet music that I used to sight read. But when they played "Tangerine" on stage first of all the harmony and the feeling that it was doing something. This time thing was something that intrigued me. And the way that Paul Desmond floated on — that was an ideal for me. And so that was the beginning.

MR: At that point had you had experience with making up music at the piano, not attached necessarily to the page in front of you?

AB: Oh yeah. No I was trying to compose, that's another side of me. But yeah I don't know ask the question again, I'm sorry.

MR: Well I just wondered, when you were listening to Desmond float over the band, and he's making up these countermelodies etcetera over the chords, had you had that experience yourself yet?

AB: No. I see, yeah. I was more or less free improvising whatever — a 14, or 13-year-old doesn't have any structure or know what's going on. But here was a structure that I understood from my dad's sheet music of the standards, like I said, and here was this thing being put on top of it that was — well it was not only interesting and intriguing, it was moving. Something was moving me. And that's how I began to search into, well — you know, who made this happen.

MR: If you turned on your favorite radio station at the time, it probably would have been AM, what kind of music were you likely to hear in Auckland at that time, early '60s?

AB: I think you would have heard the pop music of England and that would have been The Beatles and all that was starting to happen, The Stones. And just before that there were Tommy Steele, there were these English artists who went on to do Finian's Rainbow I think, Tommy Steele was a big rock star in England, people like that, Gene Pitney — he was American with the "Town Without Pity" or something like that.

MR: Yes exactly.

AB: My kind of pop music.

MR: Yeah. Did you ever put on — have the record player near the piano and put on recordings and try to poke along and see what was going on?

AB: No I didn't have the means to do that at the time. But I knew intuitively how to do it and I answered an ad of some like-minded kids that wanted to form a group and that was my first time with a bass player, drummer, and we were all trying to create this feeling, you know, of thousands of miles away from where it really was happening, and I had to find a way to get over the ocean and experience it.

MR: Well said. Did it take you time or did you figure out on your own what C 7 and F major 7 and all those symbols meant?

AB: Yeah I figured all that out. But then as I was meeting friends who were musicians and I met some serious older musicians who had been playing in Sydney and they were like, one of them an absolutely great jazz pianist, Dave McRae. Dave became, through a chain of circumstances, Buddy Rich's piano player in the '70s and Buddy's favorite pianist. Dave could groove like mad. But I think he's retired from all of that. So there were these — Mike Nock is another pretty famous New Zealander but he went in the (whatever you want to call it) jazz fusion thing that lost that feeling for me that I was interested in. Not that I don't admire the music or anything but I've always wanted that feeling. Otherwise I'll go and listen to an 80-piece orchestra you know.

MR: I want to pursue that for a moment. The feeling, 'cause I think I know what you mean, is it about swing?

AB: It's a deep swing. It's a very deep relationship. I'll give you the people, well the man that invented it was Louis Armstrong of course. You can hear that in his — well there's YouTube of him doing "Dinah" with his group somewhere in Copenhagen or something. And his — you know his group is chugging along [scats] but Louis, when he starts to impro— even with a few notes — where he puts those notes are, they're like, I don't know, a tension-release thing you know when his more complicated phrases happen they still have that feeling of bouncing around the ring, bouncing back into the center. And those — the lineage of that, not just my opinion — there's Lester Young and of course Bird and Bud Powell. Bud for me and for a lot of like-minded people, Bud is the one where it was no longer ornamental music. It was no longer Art Tatum, Teddy Wilson, magnificent pianists that they are. This was a speaking voice, like a horn. And Bud introduced that by way of, all right if you want Earl Hines and Nat Cole, Bud even sits at the piano kind of like Nat Cole. But it was Bud and the relationship to the deep, deep time that you can hear when he's not sick, when he's in great form. Those are the things that are precious to me and separated from all other music. So that's what I mean. You know of course I listen to all kinds of music and love it. You know I can love charts by David Rose or Percy Faith, you know it's the orchestration and the music, whatever. But when it comes to what Tristano called a life force, this life force that he believed was a human need, I don't know, in us. Art. The movement of music, deep music you know. I'm not talking about dance music or Beyoncé or whatever. Fine, whatever. I'm talking about dancing in the mind and in the heart. And — well Bud Powell said he wished it was treated with the seriousness of purpose with which he meant it.

MR: Well said. Nice quote. The person that you mentioned — we had a slight cutoff in the connection — and you said this quote from someone.

AB: Oh Lennie Tristano.

MR: Lennie Tristano, okay.

AB: I studied with him for a few years.

MR: Did musicians that rose to a certain level of notoriety in New Zealand, especially in the jazz world, was there a feeling that we need to go, as you put it, thousands of miles away to where this music came from? Was that a goal for most people?

AB: No. And it wasn't a goal for me, it was a compunction. It was — something grabbed ahold of me. It didn't grab ahold of any of my peers. And I got on a boat, damn it. I got on a boat for 300 pounds, a four berth cabin down below sea level. And I was on that boat for a month to get to New York etcetera etcetera. So when I look back on it I'm

over to Hawaii and then stop somewhere in L.A. and then another stop just to get to New York. So I figured it was easier to just get a boat and get off at the other end.

MR: Did your parents see you off on that boat?

AB: Oh yeah. And I'm eternally grateful to them for letting me go you know. I was 19. 19.

MR: Do you recall if you had a destination like you knew a person or —

AB: Yes, well I was going to Berklee College, Berklee School of Music. I got a small scholarship which sort of got me in and got me a student visa, and the rest is history.

MR: Nice history. Arranging is hard to define sometimes but when you're presented with a commission or a job or simply curiosity, to arrange something that is a common well known tune — I'm thinking — I wasn't going to get to Paul McCartney right away but I was struck by the fact that you were involved in that record "Kisses On The Bottom" and you did the chart on "My Valentine," one of his. But you also did one on "Bye Bye Blackbird." So my question is, when you're presented with this task of a well known tune, how do you conceive of a different and new setting for it?

AB: Well, Monk, I don't. I was invited by Diana Krall, who was involved in producing this album with Paul. And I've known Diana since she was like 19. She studied with me one summer when she came down from Canada. And so we've had a wonderful professional relationship in all that time. So she and Paul and her rhythm section had already put down the tracks. And Tommy LiPuma — a wonderful, wonderful guy — basically didn't want me somehow to get in the way. And I know exactly when he meant is that what they need is not something which would be inappropriate, to suddenly soar over the strings and do the whole bit, you know whatever. It's not appropriate to the task as you said. So it's a craft and it's a craft of knowing well yes, it could use a carpet here, you know? And if I could just do a simple line over the top there in this space, so I'll be in this space and the chord space will be under here. It's a very mathematical, you know, visual thing that you can do with orchestrating like this, people and their place. And then you just sort of sit back and stare at the blank page until, you know, when I see this movement I know what the chords are and perhaps I can get some counterpoint, a little subtle thing in there just so the sensitive listener can say, "Oh that's Alan there, I just heard, for half a bar."

MR: An Alanism, yes. That takes a lot of — a certain attitude, some restraint, and as you said there's a craft in that as well, to be satisfied that you've added a small bit that makes the whole that much better.

AB: That's the point. That's the point. And there are other projects I have where the producer or the artist just, "Go!" You know. And I go — appropriately so you know. Because I'm always moving: composer, arranger, you know I'm moved by the situation. I'm not trying to outdo it or anything. I always want to be a part of this song, create some kind of sub-

Natalie Cole singing "Stardust" I have another "Stardust" going on, however subtley so I can add that way and to me it has a subliminal effect on people because we're tuned to recognize things when we're listening to them. So there's a way of setting up those recognitions and orchestration, a little phrase or something. A person might not know because they're only hearing this top line, but Alan under here is adding something, "Oh, what is that?" So that's my goal is that in a standard song that I can pretend to be Mahler, whatever. No, not pretend, I can actually move people you know. And usually if I am moved at that point I know that yeah, okay, that means something. Whereas I never learned the craft (if you like) of well mediocrity. Mediocrity. I mean the craft of just knowing it all without any passion you know. And whatever I'm doing in music it has to be about some kind of passion because that's what I do.

MR: It's fairly profound. Did you have a passion to play and tour with a big band? Or was that one of the things that came up and you said, and speaking of Woody Herman, "Well yeah, I'll try that. I need a gig."

AB: Well how I joined Woody is that a great pianist/arranger Nat Pierce and the great drummer, they were both with Woody back in the heyday '60s I mean — Jake Hanna and Nat came down to hear me play at a club and it was the end of my last year and the semester and I needed a way to extend my visa and here was an opportunity. So they heard me and heard I was an arranger and I went out with Woody. So that was that.

MR: Most of the guys, you could correct me if I'm wrong, but most of the band, as time went by, became quite a bit younger than Woody. And did he take — embrace the opportunity to be introduced to music that he might not have normally considered for his band?

AB: Yeah I guess so. I mean considering some of the crap I wrote and that he was open to. I mean he was a very generous guy with that and he saw something in this kid, I don't know.

MR: Why do you call it "crap" now, in hindsight?

AB: [phone rings] I'm sorry, I'm doing the interview. Bye. I'm sorry.

MR: That's all right.

AB: No I guess I shouldn't say that kind of stuff but I will say this about that 20-year-old, 22, 23, is that whatever I wrote, the music holds up for me in general. I just didn't know what I was doing in terms of orchestration and stuff. So it's a case of if only I knew then — many times it's the other way around, if only I knew now.

MR: Did you ever have players in the band, the wind players come over and say, "Alan, there's a better way to do this." Or, "this is, on a saxophone this is just not playable very well.

AB: I did. You know? But I didn't know it back then. So, and you know Tony Klatka would

I wrote piano music and tried to figure out, well okay the trumpets go up that end and the trombones — you know. And that's what my charts sound like to me.

MR: Could you write on the bus?

AB: Not really, no, no. But that's a whole other world you know. That's over and done with. I basically fell off the bus in 1972 in Los Angeles.

MR: I see. I think I read something in this Woody Herman book that you actually fell into a hole in Japan on some Woody Herman concert?

AB: Yeah, yeah, yeah. That was a real thing. Well that's another story. No there was this gentlemen's club that we played somewhere in Tokyo, I don't know, but it had movable stages, like this you know. So the Japanese Benny Goodman band was here performing and we were under here waiting. Then we came up, like this, and we played our set. And anyway that's how I grabbed myself instead of falling into all the chains and gears below. So anyway. Long story short.

MR: Okay. I want to ask you to get sort of specific about one of your works, "Developing Story" which you were kind enough to send a link to. And I tried to do a little music analyzation at the end of the first movement because it's really gorgeous and — near the end there's a pause. It sounds like the piece is over. And there's a few seconds of silence and then you come back in. So before I describe then you come back in, do you recall writing that and scoring it and so forth and you got to that place and you paused? Because sometimes it's hard to know when things are done.

AB: Yeah. Well are you talking about when the piano quotes the little theme at the very end?

MR: Yes. I'm about to get there. Yeah. This is the end of the first movement. And after the pause you come back in and you eventually arrive, which I think was like an E major 7.

AB: Yeah. With [hits piano chord] yeah, something like —

MR: Yes. And the specific thing that I wanted to ask about is you play a piano line going up on that chord and then you do like a B flat to B at the top of this chord and it struck me as if you didn't want it to sound totally gorgeous. You wanted to throw in a little curve ball. And I wondered if I'm over-analyzing things or where those things come from?

AB: No it's not that, because I did have to think it's not yet the end. It's going to be — all that's going to come back at the very end. So I had to leave it sort of just hanging there for a bit so that you're still going well wait a minute. You know. And then I go into the second movement which is a variation of the variations and blah-blah-blah. So the third movement is a working out of some things, and here it comes. And that's when you should have that cathartic feeling that, yeah, there it is.

MR: I think you're kind to the listener because you used your resources in an interesting way starting out with the full orchestra then a piano solo, a trio, adding the orchestra back in. I

AB: Yes, well it has a curve, there's the introduction with the full orchestra which dies down, and I play the theme you know. It's my theme you know, anyway it's an honest and — well I like it. Anyway I play the theme and then the orchestra comes back in and we move to the theme variation so that you are always supposed to be reminded of this melody so that even when I'm improvising, when they listen to jazz, you know here's some, it sounds like mosquitoes and flies and all this stuff. There's no grounding for them to listen that yes, it's "All the Things You Are" and if you know the chords and stuff listen to how Bird is, you know floating over it like that. Well I made sure that you could hear this undertow all the time while I'm improvising. And then when you do hear the culmination of that that you can figure out without too much trouble, oh that's that theme again coming back. And what was the piano in C major is magnificently orchestrated in E major, the beautiful E major for a full orchestra, that same theme. So it's not a piano solo anymore, it's an orchestral — it would be like a denouement. So I haven't spelled anything out for you except these ideas that come in blocks, and any intelligent person would be able to add that to the emotion perhaps of listening to the music that's happening.

MR: Is there a non-musical story behind the piece that drives it? I think what I'm trying to ask is the music like this will elicit different emotions from different people but was there a story behind the composition that led to it? A life story?

AB: Well it's a whole — any — I guess we all have that, just an inner movie or something. But I guess that could simply be said as being about that boy who got on the boat.

MR: Yeah. Do you purposely, you mentioned that you orchestrated it for the orchestra in the key of E. Does E have a different sound than E flat?

AB: Oh yeah. Oh absolutely. E flat would be a darker sound, especially when there are strings involved, a lot of strings, and we had a lot. E becomes a bright, full, open stringed sound, but warm. E flat they've got a lot of stops on the — how's that for a piano player, folks?

MR: Yeah.

AB: Anyway you know what I mean?

MR: I do. And I'm wondering how you learned to write for strings? Because I've done a bit of it and I know enough to know that I don't know much about what they're capable of.

AB: Yeah well that's what happened to me. I really didn't have a clue. Because I was a pianist with Nelson Riddle for the last ten years of his life. I was there when he didn't — this was way past Sinatra and stuff, but he did TV shows and things. But I never asked him, I never, he was always kind of austere. A lovely guy and kind to me, but he wasn't interested in teaching in that way. So I would listen. And then eventually I got to be on the road with Natalie Cole with the "Unforgettable" album and, as her pianist. And that

mean all these guys, and there they were. So that's what I did on the bus, on the luxury bus where you felt every bump no matter how — but I had the time. And there — "Oh you mean you do that with the violins and then the violas can —" it was spelled out for me. And I suddenly could, all I thought I knew about the orchestra was my years of watching — I mean looking at scores since I was a teenager. Huge collection which I still have. They didn't teach me anything. But Johnny Mandel there were three voicings like this and blah-blah-blah. And that's when I did my first charts. And Natalie gave me my first experience. Unfortunately that all came at the very end of record companies' picking up the tab. So that sort of all ended after that, in the end of the '90s and stuff. Shame.

MR: Did it happen in a hurry?

AB: It seemed to. The digital folks were —

MR: The digital folks.

AB: Well I'm very thankful for them. I do use —

MR: Did you ever have, I know this would be kind of bizarre, get a commission to write string parts for behind a vocalist that would be played on the synthesizer?

AB: Well that was, you know, my couple, three years on the road with Natalie Cole we had an orchestra every night or every second night there would be a rehearsal during the day in a different town, wherever. Mitzy shh.

MR: I have one too.

AB: Oh okay. And I got off the road and got into Charlie Haden and another story and everything. One day I guess they were in a panic, they didn't have a keyboard player, could I come down, it'd be great to see you. So I went down to whatever gig it was in Orange County in L.A. and it was like a racetrack I think, whatever it was. And we went up and there was the brass players and everything and I'm looking for the string section. And I was the guy that had to sit at the synthesizer playing my string charts. And it was the most painful thing for me. So anyway, yeah.

MR: Yeah I had an experience like that with a casino here and they had this act called "The Rat Pack" and they did Sinatra and Dean Martin. And the whole thing was played on three keyboards. And it actually was difficult trying to re-create these things and not frown at the same time.

AB: I know, I know. Well —

MR: At what point, I'm going to assume that you've moved from paper and score pad to the computer? Or not?

AB: Not. I — there's a stage, there's a process now you know. If I'm to have any inspiration I'm usually at the piano and I'm hearing things. I'm not a pianist anymore, I'm an orchestra when I'm — so you know [plays chord on piano] I know what color that's

and paper. Because the pencil has a tactile thing if you like. But it's also part of my creative thing you know and I'm pretty fast. I have a style after many years. And then I look at it and now I can say well I envisaged that for three horns at that point but it would be nice to also have the violas on top and divisi celli playing with it. And up here in that space again I could have bassoons holding the low notes with the double basses down here, you know, etcetera, etcetera. I can see that in my sketch, my pencil sketch where I can remove or add, but if I put it straight into the computer I'm suddenly given that sound and it's the computer's — this is my orchestra over here. So I have to be sure that when I transfer it it has my ideas first about the orchestration. Then I can see if it doesn't work. But if I put it into the computer first and then think about orchestrating I can't because it's no longer malleable — I don't know what would be the word — the sound that I want changed.

MR: Yeah and I think it would preclude your ideas you might come up with. I think it would stop your ideas.

AB: The flow of them, yeah. If I'm busy wondering about the computer and whatever, yes. But there are other times of course where the computer really does help, is that I can, they say "cut and paste" but I can transpose and see what it looks like, whereas that would be a lot of pencil and erasing.

MR: Do you then pass things on to a copyist?

AB: No I don't have one, no, but I am in need of a — not a copyist anymore — what it is is a formatter, somebody who formats the part you know. There's no copying anymore, it's the computer does it, it's amazing.

MR: Yeah. Okay. I'm wondering if you have moments of, I'd guess I'd call reflection. I was watching you in Abbey Road Studios with this forest of fantastic musicians and you're conducting. Do you ever have a moment afterwards where you go, "God I'm glad I got on that boat."

AB: Oh yeah. Every day. Every day. Yeah. So yeah I still have to scratch myself for a few things like that, that's how Ralf Kemper, the producer, took it upon himself to finance the whole "Developing Story" and the Dave Brubeck album. Amazing fellow.

MR: What was his name again?

AB: Ralf, as in German, R-A-L-F Kemper. So you know, very — he loved the music, what can I say? So — I wish it sold a million copies.

MR: Did your confidence that your arrangements, your orchestrations, were going to work increase over the years? I'm thinking about those moments where you write a chart especially pre-computer, and you work for hours and days on it and the first time it gets played and you've got your fingers crossed.

AB: Yeah. They call it the "cringe moment." So you'd better be hearing what you're hearing. That's why somebody like John Williams, who sits there and just writes and then "Star Wars" comes out or something. You know it's like that's their instrument, you know what I mean? Nelson Riddle. That's his instrument. For me I had to battle with the piano being my instrument, and finding a way to break away from it. You know now I come back to it, as I said before, and it is my slave. Because I'm not hearing that, I'm hearing an oboe and two clarinets, whatever.

MR: Well your orchestral pieces are not necessarily realizations of your piano compositions. Is that a correct statement?

AB: Yeah. I would say that perhaps the single note part of it would be the song part of it, yeah. But it has to have an atmosphere of orchestration. It's got to be an orchestra you know? It's got to have this feeling. Yeah, it's not just a clarinet player and a harp and a you know. No, at all times, even if it's a soloist, we have to have the feeling that it's an orchestra you know, which is like a — how do I say — it should at all times to the audience feel like it is coming from an orchestra. Not just the strings over here and then the flutes over there and whatever. But there has to be this combination swimming around that makes it beautiful, beyond the mediocre.

MR: Back in 1974 I think you did a piece called "Variations on a Scene" —

AB: Oh my God.

MR: Which involved, it was a chamber group and the Woody Herman Orchestra and that was a lot to bite off at that time, wasn't it?

AB: No, that was the Houston Symphony Orchestra. That was a huge thing. Yeah, well I wouldn't do that anymore. But listen, again, there's some very — when I listen to it again — I was 23 — there's some quite beautiful moments [plays]. There's a big theme that comes out in the middle, yeah okay kid. The rest, the big ending —

MR: I'm impressed that you can pull that out of your memory like that.

AB: I was too, I'm going uh oh, wait a minute. I do remember, Monk. And with all of this my ending and everything was pre-B.M. which was a cataclysmic cathartic event in my life. All of that "Variations on a Scene" and the ending of it all was before-Mahler. And you know so —

MR: Are you saying that your ears were introduced to Mahler and that had an effect on you?

AB: Well he had a profound effect on me from the word go. And it makes my attempts seem so pretentious. But you know I have to think of it as just a kid who's having fun writing and doesn't know any better. Now I know better.

MR: There's an interesting anecdote about when Stravinsky wrote the "Ebony Concerto" for the Woody Herman band, and it was apparently quite the scene. And Chubby Jackson

AB: That's right. Stravinsky. Yeah. Well. I was going to mention something but I can't — what were we talking about just before that?

MR: We were talking about your "Variations on a Scene."

AB: Right.

MR: Yeah.

AB: Oh well.

MR: Okay. We'll come back to it. Yeah. The part of orchestrating, I'm wondering if you have, let me ask you about do you have two favorite things. First of all do you have favorite doublings of a melody? Combinations of instruments that you particularly like because they sound like one new instrument or something?

AB: Yeah well you see that's where Mahler comes in. That's what I really — whatever I learned from Johnny Mandel and everybody else, now it began the time of refining my ear and where Mahler, say in a particular passage in the violins while he's got this beautiful counterpoint going and you're following it all in this violin passage. Suddenly — not suddenly but somehow it becomes an oboe, and it's like transitioned into this other sound while all this other movement under this beautiful movement is going. So it's constantly changing. So if I had to choose what — I always love many flutes in unison. And one of the most beautiful examples is in Mahler's — this is where I first heard it — Mahler's Fourth Symphony, the second theme that comes in E major has this quality of him strolling in the fields you know? [plays] Four flutes — and I went oh that's the most beautiful thing. You know? There he is whistling away. Unison French horns I think for the beauty of power. The opening of Mahler's Third Symphony has eight of them. My son put it on my ringtone [plays]. And you have to remember with this guy nothing like that had ever been heard in the world before. That includes all of his symphonies. I'm not the only guy I mean you know I could name names who feel this way. Everything he did, there was nothing like it before. And he had the courage to get up every morning and open his manuscript and raise his third finger to the world and say, "Alan needs this" I'm going to write.

MR: Wow. That's powerful. I don't know if you can answer this — say it again?

AB: No you.

MR: Do you have a favorite dissonance?

AB: Actually I do. How about that? Who would have thought that question, Monk? Here it is [plays]. It's this [plays]. It's the opening of Stravinsky's wonderful ballet "Agon." If you don't know it it's a magnificently compact orchestral piece of — what do you say — of episodes you know, for two dancers. And here is the trumpet [plays] and horn [plays] and what else? Pizzicatos. [plays] which at the very end is softened. Well yeah, Igor, who

MR: Igor hated Mahler. I had a chance to listen to "The Rite of Spring" once in rehearsal by a major orchestra and I just am still stunned that such a thing exists.

AB: Oh yeah.

MR: And could be thought of I guess is the best way I can put it.

AB: Yeah. Mahler too. I had all those scores before any of my Mahler scores. "The Rite of Spring" I had since I went to Berklee and I used to listen to the recordings and I could not figure it out. The music I — but the orchestration — how? And it was Mahler who, when I came back to "The Rite of Spring" well of course, it's a science you know. It's like mathematics and there it is. Rimsky-Korsakov teaching Stravinsky.

MR: Well where does Frank Zappa fit in there?

AB: Well —

MR: And the reason I brought it up is I see that you chose one of his tunes to write a chart on.

AB: Yeah well that was back in the day, and it was a fun tune, but you know I'm struggling myself even at this age I struggle every day to do this. But who am I to say? I feel there's a touch of dilettantism with Frank you know. But like I said, who am I?

MR: You want to —

AB: No I'm just not moved, that's all.

MR: Okay.

AB: So why listen?

MR: It doesn't have that deep thing —

AB: Maybe it does to somebody else but I don't have enough time. I'm still trying to figure out the mysteries of the Ninth Symphony of Mahler you know, not to mention the Tenth. You know there are all these — what my son — who is 23 now — that my son with all the videogames and stuff, there are these things, what are they called — like they're hidden treasures they're called. They have a name for it, oh heck he's not here. But they're like in the game itself there are these little things that you'll find that add points. So you might sort of miss them as you're going by but ooh there's one. And that's happening to me constantly in a Mahler symphony. It's like, oh you mean that little phrase there that I've been listening to for twenty years is that one that's down there, that he's down in the basses, oh. You know stuff that any scholar could have just pointed out to me in a half a minute, but the sense of self discovery that I have with this music is —

MR: I had that with my second listen through to back to your "Developing Story," the first movement, only the second time I was hearing things I hadn't heard before, some counter melodies in the cello and so forth. Very beautiful.

AB: Thank you, Monk.

MR: Congratulations. I'm not sure —

AB: But then again the second movement is kind of a movement d'amore. But it's the same theme only cleverly composed upside-down which people will eventually get.

MR: Okay. I think I learned about that in music theory, something about a retrograde something.

AB: You've got it. There you go.

MR: Do you have a person, a manager, someone between you and potential work? If an up-and-coming singer said, "Oh I sure wish we could get Alan Broadbent to write strings for us" do they call you directly or do you have someone who handles that?

AB: No they call me directly. I'm not part of the music business. I never really was. People think I'm writing all this music but as I said all that died with the record companies not wanting to foot the bill. And so orchestras kind of died with it. But there is a way to keep that going and to schmooze and play the whole scene, and you know write other kinds of material, I never could. So people recognize something in me and they like it or —

MR: Is it harder to write a horn section part, let's say three horns than it is to have a whole orchestra at your disposal?

AB: I'd rather have the orchestra. Yeah. Yeah I can see that it would be a challenge of course.

MR: And what's it like for other people to conduct your work?

AB: Well funny you should mention it. You see this?

MR: Yup.

AB: I wrote a huge orchestral piece over the course of another twenty-something years and I came up with one more piece about a year ago that I spent a lot of time on. And I called it the "Americana Suite" because it has a lot of connections with my youth and blah-blah and you know adventures. And Ralf Kemper called the conductor of the Aachen, Germany symphony orchestra, Aachen, for anybody's information is the home of, was the home of Charlemagne so he's got a symphony orchestra. And the conductor said yes, so in February I got my fly miles and flew over there and they performed this. They had like four rehearsals and it was recorded at the time of the pandemic but performed about a year later. And that was an answer to your question —

MR: About your expectations of your piece when someone else is conducting it?

AB: That's right. Yeah this was my first experience. And the conductor, a wonderful English conductor, Christopher Ward, he also conducts the Memphis Orchestra I think, he took it upon himself and conducted — oh man — it was just a wonderful thing to see. So I'm sorry to go on but it's like yes, somebody believing in music that I believed in. It's not commercial stuff you know, it's not high art but it's my best attempt and to see somebody like on a court going like that or cuing this and it's all visceral to me because I know what he's doing and he's getting results you know. So that's a wonderful feeling,

know, and there it is. And it says it on paper there with my pencil that went into the computer. So that's a joyous feeling. And the other thing too is the German audiences, they're a different kind of animal. I mean I was sitting to the side discreetly just observing the symphony playing and a lot of the audience was sitting on the edge of their seats like listening, you know, attentively. It's like woo! So it's yeah, that's a whole experience in music, and that's why the boy got on the boat I guess is because what people do to me, what Bird did to me, what Bud in my own little reflective life I'd like to do something to somebody else.

MR: That's a wonderful way to verbalize that. And I'll wrap up here soon. How do you pass on that passion that you have to your students? Can you?

AB: I have — with a few I have, yeah. But that's the experience of improvising jazz with that feeling. So most of them that I have don't know how to play that feeling so that [plays] it's this bouncy triplet kind of thing where there's another way of playing jazz eighth notes that sink into the time, into the metronome, whatever you're using, yeah. [Plays]. "The Time is Now" thanks to Bud Powell, "The Time is Now" in my phrase, it's not in my left hand. So I've got to get them to learn fingerings that give that upbeat a stress and lay back on the time. And the way they do that is by playing very closely along with Bud Powell, which they have technical proficiency to do it, but now on YouTube you can instantly slow it down fifty percent and still get the notes. And with Bud Powell or Bird or Lester Young or Louis Armstrong, when you slow that down by half the time is not altered it's actually you can feel it more deeply because there it is and here's Louis. You can really feel how they push and pull the time like taffy. It's going down the straight line. And that's the sense of time that I try to give to my students.

MR: Yeah that's interesting. It's like putting it under a microscope. I know that I had a realization with Louis Armstrong just in his quarter notes.

AB: Yes. They're not [gestures].

MR: Hard to define —

AB: And that's the secret, and that's where the love is. I really, and it's not a technical thing. It's like Bill Evans, he hated it when people started to intellectualize about his music and stuff. It's not anything intellectual, it's about feeling. And it's true that for us, us, that the performers that are into this feeling is the feeling comes from, it's the rhythm that comes first. Become part of that rhythm. They're not placed on top of the rhythm, they are the rhythm. It is the experience.

MR: Wow. This has been a very fascinating conversation Mr. Broadbent, and I appreciate your time. Do you have a project to work on when we sign off? What are you working on right now?

AB: Well you know I have, over many years I've written standard songs, I've loved them. But they're in my own vein and they're standard songs. They don't belong anywhere out of — but there's a wonderful singer and lyricist in England, in London, Georgia Mancio, Italian-English. And she writes really, really nice stuff and we've sort of hit it off and about almost 50 of my songs over the years she's written lyrics to. So we're going to do a second album in about two weeks. I'm going over there.

MR: I wonder if one of those songs might be the melody from the Second Movement of your "Developing Story"?

AB: Oh that's interesting, yeah. But that's more of an instrumental melody you know?

MR: I can hear someone singing it.

AB: Oh thank you very much, Monk. I appreciate it.

MR: All right. Well again thanks for your time and continued luck, congratulations on your career.

AB: Thank you very much, Monk. It's been a pleasure.

MR: Thank you. I'll just sign off here and we'll say our good-byes.

AB: And yo to Hamilton College.

MR: Thank you.

AB: Take care.